DEAL INTELLIGENCE

25.3 Acres of Concrete Paved the Way for This Laredo IOS Deal

Realterm's acquisition shows how infrastructure scarcity, not location alone, is driving industrial outdoor storage pricing.

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A source-grounded Light Tower Insight. The complete note follows.

Twenty-five point three acres of concrete paved the way for this deal. That is the number that matters in Realterm's acquisition of a 40-acre industrial outdoor storage facility in Laredo, Texas. Not the total acreage, not the check-in station, not the wash bay. The concrete. Because in industrial outdoor storage, the ground is the asset, and not all ground is created equal.

Realterm, a global investment manager focused on transit-oriented properties, purchased the facility at 14610 Mines Road. The property features 25.3 concrete-paved acres that house a 22,250-square-foot check-in station, a 6,800-square-foot office, and a 3,000-square-foot wash bay. That portion of the facility was leased to transit firm Heartland Express at the time of sale. The seller and sales price were not disclosed.

The transaction matters because it reveals how IOS capital is now underwriting infrastructure scarcity, not just location. Laredo is the busiest inland port in the United States, handling more than 40 percent of all U.S.-Mexico trade. The demand for truck staging, trailer storage, and cross-dock operations is structural. But the supply of paved, graded, and permitted IOS land in that corridor is not keeping pace. Concrete is the bottleneck.

Realterm is not buying dirt. It is buying a surface that can handle 80,000-pound loads in any weather, that drains, that does not turn to mud, that meets environmental standards, and that a tenant like Heartland Express can use immediately without spending a dollar of their own capital. The 25.3 paved acres are the operating asset. The remaining 14.7 acres are either unpaved, unbuildable, or reserved for future development. The market is pricing the paved acres, not the total.

This is a pattern visible across the IOS sector. Investors are no longer satisfied with a location near a port or a rail terminal. They want to know the bearing capacity of the pavement, the age of the asphalt, the drainage plan, and the environmental status. A site that requires six months and $2 million in grading and paving before it can generate a dollar of rent is a different asset than one that can take a truck tomorrow. The market is beginning to price that difference explicitly.

The Heartland Express lease is the second signal. Heartland is a publicly traded trucking and logistics firm with a market capitalization of roughly $1.5 billion. It is not a startup or a speculative operator. It is a tenant that can pay rent, that needs the space, and that has alternatives. The fact that it chose this facility, at this location, with this pavement, tells the market that the asset is functional and the location is defensible. A lease to a credit tenant on a specialized asset is worth more than a lease to a generic tenant on a generic building. The capital markets are beginning to recognize that distinction.

The undisclosed price is frustrating but not unusual. IOS transactions are often private because the assets are heterogeneous and the comps are thin. A 40-acre facility in Laredo with 25 paved acres is not comparable to a 40-acre facility in Dallas with 35 paved acres. The price per acre is meaningless without the pavement ratio, the tenant credit, the lease term, and the environmental condition. The market is still learning how to price these assets, and the lack of transparency is a sign of an emerging asset class, not a broken one.

For owners of IOS assets near major trade corridors, the implication is clear: the value is in the pavement, not the parcel. A site with 80 percent paved coverage, a credit tenant, and a long lease will command a premium that a site with 50 percent coverage and a speculative tenant will not. The capital is flowing to the infrastructure, not the land. Owners who can demonstrate the quality of their pavement, the durability of their drainage, and the creditworthiness of their tenants will have an advantage in the next cycle.

For lenders underwriting IOS, the question is whether they are pricing the concrete or the dirt. A loan secured by a 40-acre site with 25 paved acres is not the same risk as a loan secured by a 40-acre site with 10 paved acres. The recovery value in a default depends on whether the next user can operate the site as-is or must spend capital to make it functional. Lenders who treat all IOS as homogeneous are mispricing risk.

Realterm's acquisition in Laredo is not a signal that IOS is hot. It is a signal that the market is maturing. The buyers are getting more specific. The tenants are getting more selective. The capital is getting more discriminating. And the concrete is getting more valuable.

SOURCES

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